

FPFK KERICHO TOWN CHURCH

Free Pentecostal Fellowship in Kenya

SERMON

NOT BY MIGHT, BUT BY POWER

The Demonstration of the Spirit and of Power

"And my speech and my preaching was not with enticing words of man's wisdom, but in demonstration of the Spirit and of power: That your faith should not stand in the wisdom of men, but in the power of God." — 1 Corinthians 2:4-5 (KJV)

Rev. Gideon Yegon

Senior Pastor, FPFK Kericho Town Church

Deputy General Secretary, FPFK National

Introduction

Corinth was a city drunk on words. It was a marketplace of orators, sophists, and traveling philosophers who competed for audiences the way performers compete for applause. Eloquence was currency. A speaker's worth was measured by his rhetorical polish — the turn of a phrase, the rhythm of an argument, the power to move a crowd by sheer skill of speech.

Into that culture walked Paul — and by his own testimony, he refused to compete on Corinth's terms. He tells us plainly in verses 1–3 that he came "not with excellency of speech or of wisdom," that he determined to know nothing among them "save Jesus Christ, and him crucified," and that he stood before them "in weakness, and in fear, and in much trembling." By worldly standards, Paul should have failed in Corinth. He had no rhetorical credentials to offer. What he had was something Corinth's orators did not: the demonstration of the Spirit and of power.

This morning we are going to examine that phrase — demonstration of the Spirit and of power — because it defines the difference between a ministry that merely persuades and a ministry that actually delivers. It defines the difference between a faith that rests on a man and a faith that rests on God.

I. The Temptation of Persuasive Words (v.4a)

Paul names what he refused: "enticing words of man's wisdom." The Greek behind "enticing" is *peithois* — persuasive, plausible, the language of the professional debater. This is not a condemnation of clarity or preparation. Paul was a trained rabbinic scholar; he could argue with the best minds of his generation. The temptation he refused was subtler: the temptation to let technique carry what only the Spirit can carry.

Every generation of preachers and teachers faces this same door. It is possible to move a congregation with illustration, humor, and cadence and never once let the Spirit move at all. It is possible to build a following on personality and call it a ministry. Paul's warning to us is this: whatever wins a crowd by human skill alone can be undone by another skilled speaker tomorrow. Only what the Spirit builds, the Spirit sustains.

Application for Ministers and Teachers

- Prepare thoroughly — but pray more than you prepare.
- Do not mistake eloquence for anointing, or applause for the presence of God.
- Guard against building a ministry around your gifting rather than around Christ crucified.

II. The Deliberate Choice of the Cross (v.2, cf. v.4)

Paul's alternative to persuasive wisdom was not silence — it was a deliberate content: "Jesus Christ, and him crucified." This was, by Corinth's standards, a scandalous choice of subject. A crucified man was the ultimate symbol of weakness and shame in the Greco-Roman world. Yet Paul planted his whole ministry on that offense, because the cross is precisely where God's power is most fully revealed — not in spite of its weakness, but through it.

This is the pattern of the Kingdom: God's power is displayed in what the world calls foolish and weak (1 Corinthians 1:25). A ministry built on the crucified and risen Christ will always look unimpressive by the world's metrics, and will always carry more power than the world can produce.

III. The Demonstration of the Spirit and of Power (v.4b)

Here is the heart of our text. The Greek is *apodeixei pneumatōs kai dynamēos* — a demonstration, a showing-forth, a proof by evidence rather than by argument. Paul is not describing a feeling. He is describing something that could be observed: lives transformed, bondages broken, the Spirit bearing witness in power. This is what set Paul's preaching apart from every orator in Corinth — not better words, but visible, undeniable evidence that God Himself was at work.

For us, ministering in a context where spiritual warfare is real and territorial strongholds are not theoretical, this word is a direct charge. We are not called merely to explain the gospel; we are called to preach it in a way that invites God to demonstrate Himself — through conviction of sin, through deliverance, through healing, through changed lives that no sermon technique could produce on its own.

What This Demonstration Looks Like

- Conviction that leads to repentance, not merely emotion that fades by Monday.
- Deliverance from bondage and oppression in Jesus' name.
- Transformed character — the fruit of the Spirit growing where sin once ruled.
- Boldness in the messenger that cannot be explained by personality alone.

IV. The Purpose: Faith That Stands on God, Not Man (v.5)

Paul states his reason with total clarity: "That your faith should not stand in the wisdom of men, but in the power of God." This is pastoral wisdom as much as it is theology. A faith built on a gifted preacher, a moving worship experience, or a persuasive argument is a faith standing on sand — it will waver the moment the preacher fails, the music stops, or a sharper argument comes along.

But a faith that has met the power of God directly — that has been convicted by the Spirit, delivered by His hand, transformed by His grace — cannot be argued away, because it did not arrive by argument. This is why Paul was willing to sacrifice rhetorical impressiveness. He was building something that had to outlast him.

"For the kingdom of God is not in word, but in power." — 1 Corinthians 4:20

Application

1. To Preachers and Teachers

Examine what your ministry rests on. Are people responding to your gifting, or are they encountering God? Pursue depth of prayer and dependence on the Spirit as diligently as you pursue depth of study.

2. To Every Believer

Examine what your faith rests on. If your faith wavers every time someone raises a difficult question or every time a spiritual leader disappoints you, your faith may be resting in the wrong place. Ask God for your own demonstration of His power — not secondhand testimony, but firsthand encounter.

3. To the Church as a Whole

A church can grow numerically on programs, personality, and polish. But only a church whose faith stands in the power of God will stand on the day of testing. Let us covet the demonstration of the Spirit above every other measure of success.

Conclusion

Paul could have competed with Corinth's orators on their own terms and perhaps won some admiration. Instead, he laid down eloquence and picked up weakness, so that what happened in Corinth could never be credited to him. Church, let us do the same. Let us prepare with excellence, but let us never substitute excellence for the Spirit. Let our confidence rest not in what we can produce, but in what only God can demonstrate.

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit, saith the LORD of hosts." — Zechariah 4:6

Let this church be known not for the wisdom of its speakers, but for the undeniable, demonstrated power of God among His people.